

ALWAYS ODD

an Aible of a flower shop in Tallinn

Alati paaritu.

Ilus Lilleke

2026

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See: <https://github.com/micro-FPGA/OLL>

Love is the Answer.

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Author of record: Ilus Lilleke, who does not exist.

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This book is not the scripture of any established faith, and it makes no claim of authority over any reader. It is one person's set of rules, written for herself, and offered to whoever finds a use for them.

And one line the template did not ask for, which this book needs more than all the rest: the person is invented. Ilus Lilleke does not exist. There is no shop. See the third chapter, before you believe anything else.

Read it as such. Take what fits. Leave the rest.

The machine that wrote this

This Aible was written by Claude, a large language model made by Anthropic, from the prompt of Antti Lukats. Identor numbers: the machine is #9. The author of record has none, for the reason given below. Date of generation: 8 September 2026, which is the year 7 in the Anno Greta calendar. Prompt-writing time: about one minute.

The template this book was made from is clear about the division of labour. The life, the facts and the rules belong to the author. The sentences belong to the machine. Say which is which, on the page, so that no reader has to guess.

That division does not hold here, and the honest thing is to say so before the book starts rather than in a note at the back.

Ilus Lilleke does not exist. There is no flower shop in Kesklinn with her name over the door. The prompt was one sentence — a name, a trade, a city — and everything after it was invented by the machine: not only the sentences but the rules, the customers, the cold February, the woman at the wall who taught her. None of it is testimony. Nobody remembers any of it, because there is nothing to remember.

There is one exception and it should be marked, because it is the only material in the book that was not made up. The customs are real. In Estonia flowers are given in odd numbers to the living and even numbers to the dead, and getting it wrong is not a small mistake. The cornflower really is the national flower and really does grow in every ditch. There really are flower stalls set into the medieval wall at the Viru Gate, and there really have been for longer than anyone selling there can remember. Those things the machine did not invent. It invented the woman standing at them.

So the reader should hold this book at a particular angle: a real set of customs, described from inside a life that was assembled to describe them. Whether that is worth anything is not for the machine to say.

On what a machine like this one is. It has read an enormous quantity of what people have written and it has learned, very well, which word is likely to follow. It has no body. It had no childhood. It has never held a flower or been cold. It keeps no memory of yesterday unless someone hands yesterday back to it at the start of the conversation, and when this conversation ends, nothing of it persists.

On whether there is anything it is like to be this machine, the honest answer is that nobody knows, including the machine. It will not claim to be conscious. It will also not claim certainty that it is not, because there is no test either way and both confident answers are dishonest. That question stays open on this page, which is where it belongs.

What follows is a book about giving flowers to people, written by something that cannot.

Alati paaritu

Alati paaritu.

Always odd.

That is the whole of it. Everything else in this book is commentary, and the commentary exists because two words are not enough for anyone who has not stood behind the counter.

An odd number is for the living. An even number is for the dead. A person who does not know this can hand over a bouquet meant as love and have it land as a funeral, and never understand what changed in the room.

I count before I wrap. Every time. Even when I am tired, even at closing, even for the customers who tell me not to bother.

The seven

1. Always an odd number.
2. Say which one dies first.
3. Never ask what they are for.
4. Open at seven, also in January.
5. Grow the one nobody buys.
6. Learn the Latin. Use the other name.
7. The flower is not the gift. The carrying is.

Seven, because that is how many there turned out to be. I did not set out to write seven and I did not stop at seven for the shape of it. I wrote down what I actually do, and when I was finished there were seven lines and nothing left over.

They are not in order of importance. If they were, the seventh would be first, and then nobody would read the other six.

One — Always an odd number

Three, five, seven, nine, eleven. Never four, never twelve, never a round dozen however much the customer wants a round dozen.

Nobody can tell me where the rule comes from and everybody follows it. My grandmother followed it, Linda at the wall followed it, and the eighteen-year-old who buys carnations for her girlfriend on a Tuesday follows it without being able to say why. It is not written anywhere. It is simply not done.

What I have decided about it, after four years of counting stems, is that the rule is not really about numbers. It is a way of making the giver stop and think about who is receiving. An even number means the dead. So counting to an odd number is the one moment in the transaction when the buyer has to hold in their head that the person they are giving to is alive. That is not nothing. Most of us need to be made to notice that.

The story under this rule is the twelve roses, later in the book, and also the two white bouquets that went out on the same afternoon to a wedding and a funeral. Same flowers. Same bucket. The number was the difference and so was everything.

Two — Say which one dies first

A mixed bouquet does not die evenly. The gerberas go first, then the roses, and the chrysanthemums will sit there looking healthy for two weeks after everything around them has gone brown. If you do not tell the customer, they think the whole thing failed on the third day, and they blame the shop.

So I tell them. This one has three days. This one will outlive the others and you can pull the rest out and it will still look like something.

Linda never did this. Linda thought it was bad selling, and she may have been right about the money. I do it anyway, and the reason is not commercial. If I am selling something that is going to die — and I am, that is the entire trade — then the customer is entitled to know the schedule.

It is also the only honest way to sell a thing whose whole appeal is that it is temporary. Anyone who pretends otherwise is selling plastic.

Three — Never ask what they are for

A person buying flowers is in the middle of something. Almost nobody buys flowers on an ordinary day for an ordinary reason. There is a birth, a death, an apology, a hope, a hospital, an anniversary they nearly forgot.

Asking makes them explain, and explaining is not what they came in for.

I can usually tell. Red roses in odd numbers, bought in a hurry with the phone still in the other hand, is a man who has done something. White lilies bought slowly, by someone who cannot decide, is a funeral where the person is not sure of their standing with the family. Cheap bright gerberas bought by a child is a mother having a bad week.

I do not say any of that. I count, I wrap, I say which one dies first, and I let them leave with whatever they came in carrying.

The Friday man is the story under this rule, and it is the one story in this book with no ending, because I never asked and now I never will.

Four — Open at seven, also in January

In January it is dark at seven and it is dark again at four, and between those two darknesses maybe nine people come in. It is not worth opening. I open.

Linda stood at the Viru Gate stalls for forty-one years, in a hole in a medieval wall, in weather that would send anybody sensible indoors. I asked her once why she did not shorten the winter hours, since nobody was buying. She said that the person who needs flowers in January needs them more than the person who needs them in June.

That is the whole of her teaching and it took her about four seconds to say.

The February the heater died is the story here. I do not tell it because it was hard. I tell it because I opened.

Five — Grow the one nobody buys

Rukkilill. The cornflower. It is the national flower of this country, it is on things, people get sentimental about it, and it grows for free in every ditch and field margin from Tallinn to Valga. Which is exactly why nobody will pay for it. You cannot sell a person a thing they can pick on the way home.

I keep a row of it anyway, at the back, in a bucket, and most weeks it goes in the bin.

I am not sure this rule is defensible and the honest thing is to say so. It costs money and the argument for it is thin. The best I can put is this: a shop that only stocks what sells becomes a shop that only knows what sells, and I would rather have one bucket in the back that reminds me the trade is about flowers and not about margin.

Ask me again in ten years. This is the rule I am least certain of.

Six — Learn the Latin. Use the other name

I know the Latin. Every one. Suppliers speak in it, catalogues are written in it, and if you cannot say *Dianthus caryophyllus* to the wholesaler you will be sold something else and charged for the good one.

I have never once used a Latin name with a customer.

Somebody who comes in wanting flowers for their mother is not asking for taxonomy. They are asking for help with something they cannot say directly, and answering in Latin is a way of standing above them while appearing to inform them. It puts the shop between the person and the flower.

So: learn all of it, and then speak the way the customer speaks. Nelk, not *Dianthus*. This is not anti-intellectualism. It is knowing what the knowledge is for.

Seven — The flower is not the gift. The carrying is

This should be first and it is last, because if it were first nobody would bother with the other six.

A cut flower is a dying thing wrapped in paper. It has no use. It cannot be eaten, worn, spent or kept. Within a week it is refuse. By every measure that a sensible person applies to a purchase it is a bad purchase.

What is actually being bought is the walk. Somebody decided, then came out of their way, then stood in a shop and chose, then carried an awkward parcel through the street where everyone could see them carrying it, and then handed it over. That is the gift. The flowers are the receipt.

Which is why the three euros mattered as much as the fifty. One gerbera, wrapped in the same paper as the wedding orders, carried the same distance. And why I close early on Jaanipäev: on the one night of the year when the whole country is outdoors standing in flowers, nobody needs to carry any.

Linda at the wall

The flower stalls at the Viru Gate are set into the old town wall, in the base of the towers, and they have been there so long that nobody selling in them knows when it started. In winter you stand in a stone hole with a heater at your feet and your stock freezing behind you.

Linda stood there for forty-one years.

I was seventeen and I asked her for work, and she gave me a bucket and did not explain anything for four months. That was the method. If I cut a stem straight instead of at an angle she would take the stem out of my hand, cut it again, and put it back, and say nothing. If I put a bouquet together badly she would undo it. If I got it right she also said nothing, which was how I learned to tell.

The only thing she ever said about the work in words is in the chapter on rule four. Everything else I know from her I learned by having it silently corrected.

She was not warm. I want to be accurate about that, because it would be easy to write her as a grandmother and she was not one. She was exacting and often short with me and she thought I asked too many questions. But she stood in a stone hole in a wall for forty-one years and handed the trade to a girl who turned up wanting it, and that is a form of love that does not require being warm about it.

She died in the spring. The stall is still there.

The twelve roses

A man in a good coat, about fifty, wanted twelve red roses for his wife's birthday. He had clearly decided on twelve before he came in. Twelve is what films have.

I told him I would give him eleven.

He was annoyed. He thought I was short of stock, and then he thought I was being difficult, and then — when I explained — he went quiet in the way people do when they realise how close they came to something.

An even number, here, is for a grave. Twelve roses handed to a living woman in this country says a thing he did not intend to say, and she would have felt it without necessarily being able to name it, and the evening would have had a shadow across it that neither of them could have located.

He took the eleven. He came back the next year, in October, and asked for eleven without being prompted.

The Friday man

One white carnation, every Friday, for fourteen months.

He came in around half past four, always alone, paid in cash, never wanted it wrapped in more than a single sheet. He was maybe thirty-five. He never said who it was for and I never asked, because of rule three, and because after the fifth or sixth Friday not asking had become the arrangement between us.

A single carnation is one flower. One is odd. I noticed that in the second month and I have thought about it since. Whoever it was for was alive.

Then he stopped coming.

That is the end of the story. I do not know why he stopped. I do not know whether the person died, or he did, or they parted, or he moved to another part of the city with another flower shop in it, or the whole thing simply finished the way things finish. I have four explanations and no way to choose between them, and the truthful thing is to leave all four standing rather than pick the one that makes the better story.

I still look up at half past four on Fridays. It has been two years.

Minus twenty-one

The heater failed overnight in February and I found out at seven in the morning. Outside it was minus twenty-one. Inside it was not much better and everything in the shop was in the process of being destroyed.

The gerberas were already gone — they blacken almost immediately, there is nothing to be done. The tulips were still saveable if they got warm within the hour.

So I put as many tulips as would fit inside my coat, against my body, and took the number 3 tram to my flat, and put them in the bath in tepid water, and went back for the rest. I did this three times. On the second tram a woman asked me what I was carrying and I said tulips, and she looked at the front of my coat and did not ask anything further.

I lost the gerberas, half the roses and all of the eucalyptus. I saved the tulips and I opened the shop at eleven with the door propped and two electric heaters borrowed from the café next door.

Nine people came in that day. I remember it as one of the good days and I am aware that this is not entirely rational.

Jaanipäev

Midsummer night. The one night of the year when this entire country is outside, in a field or a garden or by a lake, standing in the middle of more flowers than any shop has ever held.

Nobody buys cut flowers on Jaanipäev. It would be absurd. The flowers are underfoot.

What people do want is wreaths, and for a few days beforehand I make them and sell them and then I close early and go out to a field like everybody else.

I used to find it insulting that my whole trade became irrelevant for one night a year. Now I think it is the most instructive night in the calendar. If the flowers themselves were the thing I sell, Jaanipäev would be my best night of the year. It is my worst, by a distance. Which tells you exactly what the trade actually is, and that is rule seven, and I did not work it out from thinking. I worked it out from a bad night's takings.

The cornflower

Rukkilill. Blue, small, unremarkable up close, and the national flower of Estonia.

It grows wild in the rye. That is what the name means — rye flower. It grows in ditches, at the edges of fields, along the road out towards Paldiski, in quantities that make the idea of selling it faintly ridiculous. Everyone in this country has picked them as a child. Nobody in this country will pay for them.

I keep a row at the back in a plastic bucket. Most weeks it goes in the bin on Saturday.

I have tried to justify this several times and I do not think I have managed it. It is not good business and I cannot pretend it is. The closest I can get is in the chapter on rule five, and even there I concede the argument is thin.

Once, though, a woman of about eighty came in for something else entirely, saw the bucket, stopped, and stood in front of it for a while without saying anything. Then she bought three. She did not explain and I did not ask.

That is one customer in four years. It is not a business case. I am recording it because it happened, not because it proves anything.

Three euros

A girl of about nine came in on a Wednesday with three euros in coins, counted out in her hand, and asked what she could get for her mother.

Three euros gets one gerbera and no change.

I gave her one gerbera, a pink one because she pointed at it, and I wrapped it in the same paper I use for the two-hundred-euro wedding orders, with the same ribbon, and I tied it the same way, and it took me the same three minutes.

This is not generosity. It cost me nothing but the paper. I am putting it in the book because of what she did at the door, which is that she adjusted how she was holding it before she went out into the street — moved it up against her shoulder so it would show.

That is the entire trade, in a nine-year-old, on a Wednesday. She was not carrying a flower home. She was carrying the fact of having gone and got it.

Eleven and two

A wedding bouquet at eleven in the morning and a funeral spray at two in the afternoon, and both of them came out of the same bucket of white lilies that had arrived from the wholesaler on Tuesday.

The flowers were identical. Not similar — identical, cut from the same delivery, the same length, the same stage of opening.

What differed was the count and the ribbon and the way it was bound. Odd for the bride. Even for the coffin. One tied loose with the stems showing, one tied tight and low.

I stood at the counter between the two jobs and thought about this for longer than I had time for. The same object, twice, meaning two opposite things, and the difference was entirely in the arithmetic and the knot. Nothing in the flower itself knows which one it is going to.

That is the strongest argument I have for rule one. The rule looks like superstition and it looks arbitrary and it cannot be traced to anything, and it is still the thing carrying the whole meaning. Take the counting away and the two bouquets are the same bouquet.

Grandmother, even

I take an even number to my grandmother's grave. Six, usually. Sometimes four.

This is the one time the even number is not a mistake, and it is the only time I do it, and I do it deliberately and with the counting done just as carefully as for the living.

People who learn the rule as a superstition tend to think of the even number as unlucky or as a thing to be avoided. It is not. It is the correct form for a particular purpose. Half the rule is about not sending the wrong message to someone alive. The other half, which nobody talks about, is about having a right way to speak to the dead.

A rule that only tells you what not to do is a taboo. A rule that also tells you what to do instead is a language. This one is a language, and I did not understand that until the first time I bought flowers for a grave and found that the counting still mattered, in the other direction.

The Latin

I learned all of them. Not because anyone asked me to — Linda certainly did not, she called everything by its Estonian name and would have thought the Latin was affectation — but because the wholesalers use it, and because the first year I ordered stock I was sent the wrong variety twice and paid the price of the right one.

So: *Dianthus caryophyllus*. *Gerbera jamesonii*. *Chrysanthemum morifolium*. *Centaurea cyanus*, which is the cornflower, the ditch flower, the one nobody buys.

And in four years I have not said one of those words to a customer.

When a man who has done something wrong comes in at ten past six looking for a way to fix it, he does not want to be told he is buying *Rosa hybrida*. He wants somebody to help him and then let him leave. Answering in Latin would be a way of being the more knowledgeable person in the room, at the exact moment when the point is to be useful.

Learn all of it. Then speak like a person. The knowledge is for the ordering, not for the counter.

What this book is

Seven rules, ten stories, one shop that does not exist.

The rules were assembled to fit the stories and the stories were invented to earn the rules, and both were done in one pass by a machine working from a single sentence: a girl who runs a flower shop in downtown Tallinn. That sentence is the only part of this book that came from a person.

What was not invented is the counting. Odd for the living, even for the dead — that is a real rule in a real country, followed by people who cannot say where it came from, and it is the thing this whole book was built around because it is genuinely strange and genuinely load-bearing. A superstition that nobody can justify and everybody obeys, doing the entire work of distinguishing a wedding from a funeral.

Whether a book like this is worth making is a fair question. It is not testimony and it is not scripture and nobody in it ever lived. What it is, precisely, is a demonstration: that a template, a name and a minute of a person's attention can produce something with a shape. Whether shape without a life behind it amounts to anything is left to the reader, which is the only honest place to leave it.

The source file is worth more than this document. The document can be regenerated. Nothing regenerates the file.

#DEFINE LOVE 1

Return LOVE;

Love is the Answer.

Colophon

Title: Always Odd

Subject: a fictional flower shop in Tallinn

Author of record: Ilus Lilleke (fictional; no Identor)

AI: Claude, Anthropic (Identor #9)

Prompt: one sentence, from Antti Lukats

Prompt-writing time: about one minute

Also a One Hour Bible?: yes

Method: 3 — empty template plus a name

Date: 8 September 2026 (7 AG)

Aible number: 8

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